became Castro's leverage. His five points suggested that verification could be carried out only if the two superpowers, especially the United States, accepted Castro's demands.[9]

Although the five points were formally addressed to the United States, the Cuban minister of foreign affairs, Raúl Roa, told the Yugoslav ambassador in Havana, Boško Vidaković, they were "forwarded more to Khrushchev than to Kennedy." He added: "We have to say something when our skin is at stake." "We exist," wrote Vidaković in another cable, quoting Roa. "They have to know that—this side as well as the other side." The Polish ambassador Bolesław Jeleñ reported to Warsaw: "Cuban conditions may be calculated in order to show that Cuba participated in making the decision." He also pointed to a "very troublesome situation for Castro caused by Khrushchev's statement."[10]

Castro responded to Khrushchev's letter on the same day. "I want to inform you," he wrote, "that we are generally opposed to the inspection of our territory." But most of the letter was dedicated to an explanation of his decision to order antiaircraft fire against American airplanes—the development that had led, in Khrushchev's opinion, to the downing of the U-2. Castro advised Khrushchev to consult his own commanders: "The Soviet military leadership can provide you with additional information on how the plane was shot down." He did not rebuff Khrushchev's suggestion that it was he who had given the order to shoot down the U-2, and a few days later he told U Thant that "the plane was shot down by our anti-aircraft forces."[11]

Castro knew what had really happened but was not prepared to admit that the foreign troops on his territory were not under his jurisdiction. He had made a career in the international arena by protesting the presence of foreign bases in Latin America. Now it appeared that he had acquiesced to the establishment of a Soviet base in Cuba. Blaming the Soviets for shooting down the U-2 was tantamount to admitting that he had no control over foreign troops on his territory. Castro was not prepared to do that.

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